The Germans and Central Europe

In the previous chapters we saw how the popular mindset tends to associate Eastern Europe with the unknown and the traditional. In some instances, however, the perceived 'backwardness' is seen in what seems a more positive light – as a demonstration of appreciation for the past. Indeed, Eastern Europe is sometimes seen or portrayed as a living folk museum, where antique objects, customs and old-fashioned people can be observed, but also where traditions used to provide the only aesthetic luxuries in the otherwise grim life of the Communist past.

Such an unwanted picture of Eastern Europe is at the centre of *Molvania*[29] – a book that appeared in 2003, in which odd Eastern European customs feature prominently. (Some bookshops put it among the travel books and some among the humour.) It was designed to look like a standard guidebook with details about history, national parks, beaches, where to go, where to stay and where to eat. The only problem is that it was about an invented, stereotypical Eastern European country named Molvania – an Eastern European version of Borat's Kazakhstan. Of course, the shabbiness, ugliness, dullness, backwardness and poverty of the place are emphasised to the point of absurdity but the book is perhaps not so obviously humorous that some people will not start searching for Molvania on the map! It apparently looked more than just a parody, as the then UK Minister Keith Vaz is reported to have criticised it as exploiting prejudices.[30] *Molvania* was not the first attempt of its kind, though. In *Why Come to Slaka?* by Malcom Bradbury, first published in the 1980s, Slaka was the name (echoing Slav?) of another invented Eastern European country that was held up to ridicule.

In any event, Central Europe is indeed marked by common heritage features. The countryside of the Czech Republic, Austria, Slovenia etc. is dotted with signs of popular piety, such as small roadside chapels and wooden crucifixions in the fields, witnesses of a common Catholic tradition that unites the region.[31] Common features exist in cuisine and in artisan activity, as well as in folk music.

In this part of Eastern Europe, it was the Germanic influence that was the most important and was responsible for some of these shared traditions. The